cultural and historical links with Tibetan civilization. Nor was it simply that the Indian leadership felt a moral obligation to try to uphold the agreement. Garver suggests instead that Delhi's calculations were twofold: first, in an autonomous Tibet, the Chinese military presence would be limited and hence India would be safer; and second, the continuation of Tibetan autonomy would demonstrate that India and China could cooperate, which would be a powerful basis for a partnership in Asia and beyond. Indian pressures on China, in the form of support for the Tibetan cause and its tacit backing of US covert activities, were not intended to unravel Chinese communist rule in Tibet. Rather they aimed to push Beijing to honour the original promise of regional autonomy.[68]

Military Actions and the 1962 War

As the conflict over the border and Tibet sharpened, Indian and Chinese forces found themselves increasingly confronting each other, particularly after 1954. The two sides could never agree on who was the aggressor in terms of incursions across the border and who had fired the first shot – with two exceptions, when China admitted its troops had attacked at Longju in August 1959 and when India admitted in September 1959 that its units had crossed the McMahon Line in Tamaden. Yet, both sides did attempt to stabilize military relations and prevent a spiral into outright hostilities. It is tempting to see their actions to head off war as being deceitful and half-hearted. In fact, the record shows otherwise. India's 'Forward Policy' was defensive and not designed to subvert Tibet or grab Chinese territory. And China's military moves were tempered more by a desire to avoid a fight, at least until late September 1962, just days before Beijing finally decided to do battle.

Military moves and stabilization measures, 1954–1959